

# Disentangled Cost Learning for Air-Traffic Routing Under Potential-Shaping Invariance

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## Abstract

We present a principled framework for learning edge-cost models in directed air-traffic networks while explicitly handling two sources of ambiguity: (1) the attribution ambiguity between feature-based costs and a residual preference, and (2) the potential-shaping invariance of routing policies. By projecting both features and residuals onto the cycle space of the graph, we obtain a gauge-fixed formulation

$$c = X_{\text{cyc}} w + p, \quad BW p = 0, \quad X_{\text{cyc}}^\top D p = 0,$$

which yields identifiable, policy-relevant cost components. The paper details the mathematical derivation, implementation recipes, and practical considerations.

## 1 Setup and notation

### 1.1 Graph and costs

- Directed graph  $G = (V, E)$  with  $|V| = n$  nodes and  $|E| = m$  edges.
- Edge costs  $c \in \mathbb{R}^m$ , one scalar per edge.
- Edge-feature matrix  $X \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$ , with  $d$  features per edge.
- Feature weights  $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$ .
- Residual / preference vector  $p \in \mathbb{R}^m$ .

### 1.2 Incidence matrix and potentials

Choose an orientation consistent with the directed edges and define the *full* node-edge incidence matrix  $B_{\text{full}} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times m}$  by

$$(B_{\text{full}})_{u,e} = \begin{cases} +1 & \text{if } e \text{ leaves node } u, \\ -1 & \text{if } e \text{ enters node } u, \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

A node potential  $\phi \in \mathbb{R}^n$  induces an edge “gradient”

$$B_{\text{full}}^\top \phi \in \mathbb{R}^m, \quad (B_{\text{full}}^\top \phi)_e = \phi(u) - \phi(v)$$

for  $e : u \rightarrow v$ .

To remove the constant-potential nullspace we anchor one node (typically a goal) by dropping its row, obtaining the *reduced* incidence matrix

$$B \in \mathbb{R}^{(n-1) \times m}.$$

Equivalently, we fix  $\phi(\text{anchor}) = 0$  and represent  $\phi$  only on the remaining  $n - 1$  nodes.

### 1.3 Weight matrices

We employ two diagonal edge-weight matrices:

- $W \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times m}$ ,  $W \succ 0$ , to define the gauge-fixing / cycle-space notion.
- $D \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times m}$ ,  $D \succeq 0$ , to define the disentanglement notion.

Typical choices are  $W = I$  (global gauge fix) or  $W = D_\epsilon = \text{diag}(\hat{n} + \epsilon)$  with a small  $\epsilon > 0$ , and an analogous choice for  $D$ .

## 2 Why costs are not identifiable: potential-shaping invariance

### 2.1 Deterministic shortest path

For any origin–goal pair  $o \rightarrow g$  and a path  $\tau = (e_1, \dots, e_T)$ , the path cost is  $\sum_{t=1}^T c_{e_t}$ . If we add a potential gradient to edge costs,

$$c' = c + B_{\text{full}}^\top \phi,$$

then

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{t=1}^T c'_{e_t} &= \sum_{t=1}^T c_{e_t} + \sum_{t=1}^T (\phi(s_t) - \phi(s_{t+1})) \\ &= \sum_{t=1}^T c_{e_t} + \phi(o) - \phi(g). \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

The shift  $\phi(o) - \phi(g)$  is the same for all  $o \rightarrow g$  paths, so the argmin path(s) are unchanged.

## 2.2 Maximum-entropy (soft) path distributions

In a MaxEnt model,

$$P(\tau \mid o, g, c) = \frac{\exp(-c^\top n(\tau))}{Z_{o,g}(c)}, \quad n(\tau) \in \mathbb{R}^m \text{ counts edge usages.}$$

Adding the same potential gradient yields

$$(c + B_{\text{full}}^\top \phi)^\top n(\tau) = c^\top n(\tau) + \phi(o) - \phi(g),$$

so the constant cancels between numerator and partition function  $Z_{o,g}$ ; the distribution is unchanged.

## 2.3 Consequence

The policy (or likelihood) identifies only an equivalence class

$$c \sim c + B_{\text{full}}^\top \phi.$$

Thus, writing  $c = Xw + p$  without a gauge-fix allows the residual  $p$  to accidentally absorb an arbitrary  $B^\top \phi$  component.

# 3 Two distinct ambiguities (“gauges”) we must fix

## 3.1 Gauge A: feature–residual attribution ambiguity

Even with a fixed  $c$ , the decomposition  $c = Xw + p$  is not unique unless we constrain  $p$ . Our proposal

$$X^\top Dp = 0 \tag{1}$$

forces  $p$  to be orthogonal to the feature span under the  $D$ -weighted inner product. In words, “ $p$  contains no component explainable by the features (on the weighted support).”

## 3.2 Gauge B: potential-shaping ambiguity (policy invariance)

Even after fixing the split,  $c$  itself is ambiguous up to  $B^\top \phi$ . To ensure that  $p$  is a *policy-identifiable* preference we forbid  $p$  from containing any gradient component. This is expressed by the *cycle-space constraint*

$$BWp = 0. \tag{2}$$

Equivalently,  $Wp$  is a circulation (zero divergence at every node).

## 3.3 Combined requirement

Collecting (1) and (2) we require

$$p \in \ker(X^\top D) \cap \ker(BW). \tag{3}$$

## 4 Why $BWp = 0$ is the right “no potential component” condition

Define a  $W$ -weighted inner product on edge vectors:

$$\langle a, b \rangle_W := a^\top W b.$$

A vector  $p$  has no gradient component (in the  $W$ -orthogonal sense) iff it is orthogonal to every gradient  $B^\top \phi$ :

$$\langle p, B^\top \phi \rangle_W = 0 \quad \forall \phi.$$

Indeed,

$$\langle p, B^\top \phi \rangle_W = p^\top W B^\top \phi = (BWp)^\top \phi,$$

which vanishes for all  $\phi$  exactly when  $BWp = 0$ . Hence (2) is precisely the desired condition.

## 5 The cycle projector $P_{\text{cyc}}$ (“remove potential component”)

### 5.1 Derivation via weighted least squares

Given any edge vector  $v \in \mathbb{R}^m$  we seek the best-fitting potential gradient in the  $W$ -metric:

$$\phi^* = \arg \min_{\phi} \|v - B^\top \phi\|_W^2, \quad \|x\|_W^2 := x^\top W x.$$

The first-order optimality condition reads

$$B W (v - B^\top \phi^*) = 0 \iff (B W B^\top) \phi^* = B W v.$$

Let the reduced weighted Laplacian be

$$L := B W B^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{(n-1) \times (n-1)}.$$

Assuming  $W \succ 0$  and a proper anchor,  $L$  is symmetric positive definite. Thus

$$\phi^* = L^{-1}(B W v), \quad P_{\text{cyc}} v := v - B^\top \phi^*. \tag{4}$$

Equation (4) can be written as a matrix operator (without forming it explicitly):

$$P_{\text{cyc}} = I - B^\top (B W B^\top)^{-1} B W. \tag{5}$$

### 5.2 Key properties

(i) **Gauge removal:**

$$P_{\text{cyc}}(v + B^\top \phi) = P_{\text{cyc}} v.$$

(ii) **Cycle constraint:**

$$B W (P_{\text{cyc}} v) = 0.$$

## 6 Project features into the cycle space once and for all

### 6.1 Why we must also project $X$

Even if  $p$  satisfies (2), the feature term  $Xw$  can hide shaping: if there exist  $\Delta w$  and  $\psi$  such that

$$X\Delta w = B^\top \psi,$$

then replacing  $w \leftarrow w + \Delta w$  changes  $c$  only by a gradient, leaving the policy unchanged. Hence  $w$  is not identifiable.

### 6.2 Cycle-projected features

Define the *cycle-projected* feature matrix

$$X_{\text{cyc}} := P_{\text{cyc}} X. \tag{6}$$

By construction  $BW X_{\text{cyc}} = 0$ , so every column of  $X_{\text{cyc}}$  already lies in the cycle space.

### 6.3 Eliminating the shaping ambiguity in $w$

Suppose  $X_{\text{cyc}} \Delta w = B^\top \psi$ . Applying  $BW$  to both sides yields

$$0 = BW X_{\text{cyc}} \Delta w = L \psi,$$

and because  $L$  is invertible on the anchored component we obtain  $\psi = 0$ , hence  $X_{\text{cyc}} \Delta w = 0$ . Therefore, after (6) the only remaining non-identifiability of  $w$  is the usual linear-model nullspace (collinearity).

## 7 The recommended model

Putting the pieces together we adopt the gauge-fixed formulation

$$c = X_{\text{cyc}} w + p, \quad \underbrace{BW p = 0}_{\text{no potential component}}, \quad \underbrace{X_{\text{cyc}}^\top D p = 0}_{\text{feature disentanglement}}. \tag{7}$$

Equation (7) yields a cost vector whose residual part  $p$  is

- orthogonal to the engineered features (weighted by  $D$ ), and
- free of any gradient that could be absorbed by a potential-shaping transformation.

Consequently  $p$  captures a *policy-identifiable preference* over cycles, while  $X_{\text{cyc}} w$  accounts for the known feature-based effects.

## 8 Practical end-to-end recipe

### 8.1 Precomputation

#### 1. Inputs

- Graph  $G = (V, E)$ .
- Feature matrix  $X \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$ .
- Anchor node (often a goal).
- Diagonal weight matrices  $W \succ 0$ ,  $D \succeq 0$ .

2. **Build reduced incidence**  $B$  by dropping the anchor row.

3. **Form the weighted Laplacian**

$$L := B W B^\top.$$

Factorize  $L$  (e.g., Cholesky) for repeated solves.

4. **Cycle-project the features**

- (a) Compute  $R := B W X \in \mathbb{R}^{(n-1) \times d}$ .
- (b) Solve  $L \Phi_X = R$  for  $\Phi_X \in \mathbb{R}^{(n-1) \times d}$ .
- (c) Set  $X_{\text{cyc}} := X - B^\top \Phi_X$ .

5. **Pre-compute the  $D$ -weighted Gram matrix**

$$G := X_{\text{cyc}}^\top D X_{\text{cyc}} + \gamma I,$$

with a small ridge  $\gamma > 0$ ; factorize  $G$  as well.

### 8.2 Training loop (projected gradient)

The following pseudocode assumes we can obtain the gradient of the MaxEnt log-likelihood with respect to the edge costs  $c$  (denoted  $g_c$ ).

```
1 # Precomputed objects:
2 #   B, W, D
3 #   L = B @ W @ B.T    (factorized)
4 #   X_cyc
5 #   G = X_cyc.T @ D @ X_cyc + gamma * np.eye(d)    (factorized)
6
7 # hyperparameters
8 eta_w = 1e-3
9 eta_p = 1e-3
10 lambda_w = 1e-4
11 lambda_p = 1e-4
12
13 # initialization
```

```

14 w = np.zeros(d)
15 p = np.zeros(m)    # already satisfies BWp=0 and X_cyc.T @ D @ p = 0
16
17 for t in range(T):
18     # 1) current costs
19     c = X_cyc @ w + p
20
21     # 2) obtain model expected edge counts under current costs
22     # (implementation depends on the IRL algorithm)
23     n_model = expected_edge_counts(c, demonstrations)
24
25     # 3) gradient of negative log likelihood w.r.t. c
26     g_c = n_hat - n_model    # empirical minus expected
27
28     # 4) gradient step for w
29     w -= eta_w * (X_cyc.T @ g_c + lambda_w * (w - w0))
30
31     # 5) tentative update of p
32     p_tmp = p - eta_p * (g_c + lambda_p * p)
33
34     # 6) --- project p onto the intersection ---
35     # (a) cycle projection: p1 = P_cyc(p_tmp)
36     rhs = B @ (W @ p_tmp)
37     phi = solve(L, rhs)          # L^{-1} rhs
38     p1 = p_tmp - B.T @ phi      # now BW p1 = 0 (up to
    numerical error)
39
40     # (b) D weighted feature orthogonalisation:
41     b = X_cyc.T @ (D @ p1)
42     alpha = solve(G, b)         # G^{-1} b
43     p = p1 - X_cyc @ alpha      # preserves BW p = 0 and
    enforces X_cyc^T D p = 0

```

Listing 1: Projected gradient for  $w$  and  $p$

After convergence we return  $(w, p)$  and the final cost  $c = X_{\text{cyc}}w + p$ .

### 8.3 Why the two-step projection is exact

Because  $BWX_{\text{cyc}} = 0$ , any vector in the column span of  $X_{\text{cyc}}$  already satisfies the cycle constraint. Hence after step (a) we have  $BWp_1 = 0$ , and subtracting  $X_{\text{cyc}}\alpha$  in step (b) leaves the constraint unchanged:

$$BW(p_1 - X_{\text{cyc}}\alpha) = BWp_1 - BWX_{\text{cyc}}\alpha = 0.$$

## 9 What if we do *not* pre-project $X$ ?

If  $X$  is used directly, the two-step projection may re-introduce a gradient component when we subtract  $X\alpha$  (because  $BWX$  need not be zero). In that case we must project onto the intersection  $\ker(X^\top D) \cap \ker(BW)$  in a single solve:

$$\text{Proj}(v) = v - A^\top \lambda, \quad A = \begin{bmatrix} X^\top D \\ BW \end{bmatrix}, \quad (AA^\top)\lambda = Av.$$

While mathematically correct, this approach is computationally heavier than the pre-projected strategy described above.

## 10 Interpretation of each constraint

| Component            | Constraint                         | Meaning                                                             |
|----------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Disentanglement      | $X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp = 0$       | $p$ contains no component explainable by the engineered features (v |
| Gauge-fix (residual) | $BWp = 0$                          | $p$ contains no potential-shaping (gradient) component.             |
| Feature gauge-fix    | $X_{\text{cyc}} = P_{\text{cyc}}X$ | Features themselves are already free of gradient components.        |

Table 1: Summary of the three core constraints.

## 11 Remaining identifiability caveats

1. **Feature collinearity.** If  $X_{\text{cyc}}\Delta w = 0$ ,  $w$  is not unique. Regularisation (ridge, sparsity) or explicit constraints can mitigate this.
2. **Pure-gradient features.** Any column of  $X$  that is exactly a gradient  $B^\top \phi$  vanishes after projection ( $P_{\text{cyc}}$ ), indicating that the feature is intrinsically unidentifiable from routing choices.
3. **Disconnected subgraphs.** If some nodes are unreachable from the anchor, the reduced Laplacian  $L$  is singular on those components. One must either restrict attention to the reachable subgraph or anchor each component separately.
4. **Scaling / temperature.** In MaxEnt models, multiplying  $c$  by a constant changes the effective temperature; this is independent of the potential-shaping gauge and must be handled (e.g., by fixing a temperature hyper-parameter).

## 12 Recommended defaults (practical)

- Choose  $D = \text{diag}(\hat{n} + \epsilon_D)$  and  $W = \text{diag}(\hat{n} + \epsilon_W)$  with a small  $\epsilon > 0$  to avoid division by zero.



- Anchor a single, globally relevant node (e.g., a common destination).
- Add  $\ell_2$  regularisation on  $w$  and  $p$ , possibly weighted by  $D$ .
- Use a modest ridge  $\gamma$  when forming  $G$  to guarantee numerical stability.

## 13 Summary checklist

1. Build reduced incidence  $B$  and select a positive-definite  $W$ .
2. Factorize  $L = BWB^\top$ .
3. Compute the cycle-projected features  $X_{\text{cyc}} = X - B^\top(BWB^\top)^{-1}BW X$ .
4. Train the model  $c = X_{\text{cyc}}w + p$  using projected gradient.
5. After each  $p$  update enforce:
  - (i)  $p \leftarrow P_{\text{cyc}}p$  (cycle/gauge projection);
  - (ii)  $p \leftarrow p - X_{\text{cyc}}(X_{\text{cyc}}^\top D X_{\text{cyc}})^{-1}X_{\text{cyc}}^\top D p$  (feature disentanglement).
6. Interpret the final  $p$  as a *policy-identifiable preference over cycles*, orthogonal to the engineered features.

## 14 Response 1

### 14.1 Cycle/potential projector: algebra check

#### 14.1.1 Dimensions

- $B \in \mathbb{R}^{(n-1) \times m}$ ,  $W \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times m}$  diagonal with  $W \succ 0$ .
- $v \in \mathbb{R}^m$ ,  $\phi \in \mathbb{R}^{n-1}$ .
- $BWv \in \mathbb{R}^{n-1}$ ,  $L := BWB^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{(n-1) \times (n-1)}$ .

All products in

$$P_{\text{cyc}} = I - B^\top(BWB^\top)^{-1}BW \tag{2}$$

have consistent shape:  $B^\top(\cdot)BW$  is  $m \times m$ .

### 14.1.2 Weighted least-squares $\rightarrow$ normal equations

The objective is

$$\min_{\phi} (v - B^{\top} \phi)^{\top} W (v - B^{\top} \phi). \quad (3)$$

The gradient w.r.t.  $\phi$  is

$$\nabla_{\phi} = -2 B W (v - B^{\top} \phi), \quad (4)$$

so first-order optimality gives

$$B W (v - B^{\top} \phi^{\star}) = 0 \iff (B W B^{\top}) \phi^{\star} = B W v. \quad (5)$$

Hence

$$\phi^{\star} = (B W B^{\top})^{-1} B W v, \quad P_{\text{cyc}} v = v - B^{\top} \phi^{\star}. \quad (6)$$

These expressions are correct.

### 14.1.3 Projector properties (quick sanity)

Let  $L := B W B^{\top}$ . The following identities hold.

$$1) \quad B W (P_{\text{cyc}} v) = 0$$

$$B W (I - B^{\top} L^{-1} B W) v = B W v - (B W B^{\top}) L^{-1} B W v \quad (7)$$

$$= B W v - B W v = 0. \quad (8)$$

$$2) \quad P_{\text{cyc}}(v + B^{\top} \psi) = P_{\text{cyc}} v \text{ (because } P_{\text{cyc}} B^{\top} = 0 \text{):}$$

$$(I - B^{\top} L^{-1} B W) B^{\top} \psi = B^{\top} \psi - B^{\top} L^{-1} (B W B^{\top}) \psi \quad (9)$$

$$= B^{\top} \psi - B^{\top} \psi = 0. \quad (10)$$

3) **Idempotence:**  $P_{\text{cyc}}^2 = P_{\text{cyc}}$  Using  $B W B^{\top} = L$  one verifies  $P_{\text{cyc}}$  is idempotent.

Thus  $P_{\text{cyc}}$  removes the potential component provided  $L$  is invertible (reduced/anchored case, connected graph,  $W \succ 0$ ).

## 14.2 Weighted cycle space definition

The authors define

$$\mathcal{C}_W := \ker(BW). \quad (11)$$

Since

$$\langle B^{\top} \phi, z \rangle_W = (B^{\top} \phi)^{\top} W z = \phi^{\top} B W z,$$

$\mathcal{C}_W$  is exactly the  $W$ -orthogonal complement of  $\text{im}(B^{\top})$ . Because  $W$  is invertible,  $\ker(BW) = W^{-1} \ker(B)$ , i.e. a scaled version of the usual cycle space.

### 14.3 Pre-projecting $X$ : algebra check

Define  $X_{\text{cyc}} := P_{\text{cyc}}X$ . Then

$$BW X_{\text{cyc}} = BW(I - B^\top L^{-1}BW)X \quad (12)$$

$$= BWX - (BWB^\top)L^{-1}BWX \quad (13)$$

$$= BWX - BWX = 0. \quad (14)$$

Hence every column of  $X_{\text{cyc}}$  lies in  $\ker(BW)$ , and for any  $\alpha$

$$BW(X_{\text{cyc}}\alpha) = 0. \quad (15)$$

Thus if  $p \in \ker(BW)$  then the update  $p \leftarrow p - X_{\text{cyc}}\alpha$  stays in  $\ker(BW)$ .

### 14.4 Feature-orthogonal projection step

The authors enforce  $X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp = 0$  by

$$p \leftarrow p - X_{\text{cyc}}\alpha, \quad (X_{\text{cyc}}^\top DX_{\text{cyc}})\alpha = X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp. \quad (16)$$

This is the standard  $D$ -orthogonal projection onto  $\ker(X_{\text{cyc}}^\top D)$  along  $\text{span}(X_{\text{cyc}})$ , assuming  $X_{\text{cyc}}^\top DX_{\text{cyc}}$  is invertible on that subspace.

If a ridge term  $G := X_{\text{cyc}}^\top DX_{\text{cyc}} + \gamma I$  is used, solving

$$G\alpha = X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp$$

yields

$$X_{\text{cyc}}^\top D(p - X_{\text{cyc}}\alpha) = \gamma\alpha,$$

so the constraint  $X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp = 0$  holds exactly only when  $\gamma = 0$ . With  $\gamma > 0$  the step provides a *regularized approximate* projection.

### 14.5 Two-step projection onto the intersection

The two-step procedure reaches a point in the intersection because:

- 1) Step 1 maps to  $\ker(BW)$ .
- 2) Step 2 subtracts a vector in  $\text{span}(X_{\text{cyc}}) \subseteq \ker(BW)$ , preserving membership in  $\ker(BW)$ , and is constructed to enforce  $X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp = 0$ .

Thus feasibility in one pass is correct. The resulting operator is a linear projector onto the intersection, but not necessarily the *orthogonal* projector for a single global metric unless that metric is chosen appropriately.

## 14.6 Clarifying the $BW\phi = 0$ confusion

- 1) The equation  $BW\phi = 0$  is dimensionally inconsistent:  $BW$  maps edge vectors  $\in \mathbb{R}^m$  to node-balance vectors  $\in \mathbb{R}^{n-1}$ , whereas  $\phi \in \mathbb{R}^{n-1}$ .
- 2) One usually does *not* constrain  $\phi$  at all. Instead, fix a gauge on the edge-cost vector by applying  $P_{\text{cyc}}$ .

A clean formulation is

$$\tilde{c} := P_{\text{cyc}}c, \quad \tilde{c} = X_{\text{cyc}}w + p, \quad p \in \ker(BW), \quad X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp = 0.$$

Then  $\phi$  disappears automatically after projection, and no extra coupling constraint between  $p$  and  $\phi$  is required.

## 14.7 Bottom line

- The projector  $P_{\text{cyc}} = I - B^\top(BWB^\top)^{-1}BW$  and the associated algebra are correct.
- Pre-projecting  $X$  indeed makes the two constraints compatible, so the two-step “make  $p$  cyclic, then make it feature-orthogonal” yields a feasible  $p$  in one pass.
- Avoid writing  $BW\phi = 0$ ; the gauge should be imposed on  $c$  or  $p$ , not on  $\phi$ .
- Adding a ridge term destroys the exactness of the  $X_{\text{cyc}}^\top Dp = 0$  constraint; set  $\gamma = 0$  for exact feasibility or accept a regularized approximation.
- The two-step method is a valid linear projection onto the intersection, but it is not necessarily the orthogonal projection for a single quadratic metric.

# 15 Response 2

## 15.1 Cheapest monitor: cycle-feasibility residual

For any edge vector  $v$  (e.g., the current  $p$  or a temporary update  $p_{\text{tmp}}$ ), define

$$r_{\text{cyc}}(v) := \|BWv\|_2. \tag{17}$$

- $r_{\text{cyc}}(v) = 0$  iff  $v \in \ker(BW)$ .
- In practice one monitors this quantity *before* applying the cycle projection, because after projection it will be (up to round-off) zero.

## 15.2 Potential energy via a Laplacian solve

Let  $L := BWB^\top$  and compute the potential fit

$$\phi^\star(v) := L^{-1}BWv. \quad (18)$$

The removed potential component is  $g(v) = B^\top \phi^\star(v)$ , whose  $W$ -energy is

$$E_{\text{pot}}(v) := \|g(v)\|_W^2 \quad (19)$$

$$= \|B^\top \phi^\star(v)\|_W^2 \quad (20)$$

$$= \phi^\star(v)^\top L \phi^\star(v) \quad (21)$$

$$= (BWv)^\top L^{-1}(BWv). \quad (22)$$

Since  $P_{\text{cyc}}$  is the  $W$ -orthogonal projector, the energy splits exactly:

$$\|v\|_W^2 = \|P_{\text{cyc}}v\|_W^2 + E_{\text{pot}}(v). \quad (23)$$

A convenient normalized “cycle fraction” is

$$s_{\text{cyc}}(v) := \frac{\|P_{\text{cyc}}v\|_W^2}{\|v\|_W^2} = 1 - \frac{(BWv)^\top L^{-1}(BWv)}{v^\top Wv}. \quad (24)$$

## 15.3 Graph/weight “health” monitor: conditioning of $L$

The numerical stability of the previous quantities is governed by the spectrum of  $L = BWB^\top$ .

- $\lambda_{\min}(L)$ : a very small value indicates an ill-conditioned Laplacian solve.
- $\kappa(L) = \lambda_{\max}(L)/\lambda_{\min}(L)$ : a large condition number signals potential sensitivity in the potential estimates and projections.

## 15.4 Number of cyclic degrees of freedom

The dimension of the weighted cycle space is

$$\dim \ker(BW) = m - \text{rank}(BW). \quad (25)$$

For a connected graph with one anchored node and  $W \succ 0$ ,  $\text{rank}(BW) = n - 1$ , so

$$\dim \ker(BW) = m - n + 1. \quad (26)$$

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## References

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